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THE QATAL VERB FORM AND THE CONJUNCTION *ix* IN BIBLICAL HEBREW¹

ABSTRACT

*When the disjunctive conjunction *ix* (or) connects two verbal clauses, the form of the verb in the second clause seems to vary according to its proximity to the conjunction. This article examines all instances of clauses coordinated by *ix* in the Hebrew Scriptures and discusses the observation that, when a verb immediately follows the conjunction, it is almost invariably a qatal form regardless of form of the verb in the preceding coordinating clause. I argue that when a qatal verb immediately follows the *ix* conjunction, it functions as a type of a default verb and that the tense and aspect of the *ix* + qatal verb is derived from the tense-aspect of the previous coordinate clause to which it is conjoined. This conclusion naturally leads one to reflect on how *ix*+ qatal forms should be translated.*

1. INTRODUCTION

The disjunctive conjunction *ix* (or) occurs 321 times in the Bible. This is in contrast to the thousands of occurrences of the *waw*, which in some cases can also be translated ‘or.’ *ix* is found most frequently in the legal texts, in particular in Leviticus – 137x, but also occasionally in narrative and prophetic texts. The conjunction is also found in rabbinic literature, especially in the context of discussions on biblical law.

The conjunction *ix* (or) can be found between adjectives, nouns and noun phrases, adverbial phrases, between verbs in verb phrases, subordinate clauses, and entire sentences. It can be found coordinating two questions, two statements, two quotes, or two or more conditions. Most frequently, it occurs between nouns and noun phrases as well as adverbial phrases. This paper focuses on those instances where the *ix* conjunction coordinates verbs, clauses and sentences. These account for 60 of the 321 instances of the conjunction in the Hebrew Bible.

The *ix* conjunction has been the subject of very little discussion in the literature. Almost all dictionaries and grammars consulted² have only a

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² See the bibliography for a list of grammars and lexicons consulted.

very brief note on the conjunction, indicating its basic meaning, along with a few random examples. Two exceptions are Brin's chapter on "The use of 'OR' (**וְ**) in Biblical Legal Texts" (1994) and Andersen's chapter on "Disjunctive Sentences" (1974) from a tagmemic perspective.

This study was prompted by the observation while reading the biblical text that, when a verb directly followed **וְ**, it was almost invariably in the *qatal* form, even when the verb in the preceding coordinating clause was *yiqtol*. In other words, the sequence appeared to act like a *waw* consecutive string. Andersen (1974: 146) was the only author (to my knowledge) to take note of this phenomenon: "When a series of future or conditional actions are described sequentially by means of WS clauses, and there is a branch in the chain due to alternative possibilities, **וְ** maybe used with the VS and the tense is sequential future. In other words, **וְ** acts just like *waw*-consecutive in paragraph-level disjunction." He gives four biblical references as examples of the phenomenon and then adds, "in other contexts, VS after **וְ** is simply past tense."

2. PRESENTATION OF THE DATA

The behaviour of this **וְ** + *qatal* sequence will be best understood in the light of a study of all of the 60 sentences in which the **וְ** conjunction coordinates verbs, verbal clauses and sentences. Below is an examination and classification of clauses according to the verb forms preceding and following the conjunction.

2.1 **וְ** + *X* + *Verb*

In most cases the verb form before the **וְ** conjunction is the same as the verb form following the conjunction, especially if there is another element between the conjunction and the verb.

2.1.1 *yiqtol/weqatal* + **וְ** *X* *yiqtol*

There are at least 26 instances of the **וְ** *X* *yiqtol*. We give a few examples here followed by a list of other references. In each case the *yiqtol* is found both before and after the **וְ** conjunction. And in each case an element is found between the conjunction and the verb. It can be a noun, a question particle, a subordinate conjunction, or an absolute infinitive form of the verb. Here are several examples:

(1) Exod 19:13a

לֹא-תִגַּע בּוֹ יָד כִּי-סֹקֵל יִסָּקֵל אֹיְיָרָה יִיָּרָה

*No hand must touch (yiqtol) him, for he shall be stoned
(absolute infinitive + yiqtol) or shot (abs.inf. + yiqtol)*

(2) Exod 21:33

וְכִי־יִפְתַּח אִישׁ בּוֹר אוֹ כִּי־יִכְרֶה אִישׁ בָּר וְלֹא יִכְסֶּנּוּ וְנָפַל־שָׁמָּה שׁוֹר
אוֹ חֲמֹר:

If a man opens (yiqtol) a pit, or if a man digs (yiqtol) a pit and does not cover (yiqtol) it, and an ox or an ass falls (weqatal) into it,

(3) Lev 26:40- 41 40 And(If) they will confess (weqatal)...

אֲפ־אֲנִי אֵלַי עִמָּם בְּקָרִי וְהִבַּתִּי אֹתָם בְּאֶרֶץ אֹיְבֵיהֶם
אוֹ־אֲזַי יִכְנַע לְבָבָם הָעֶרְלִי וְאֲז יִרְצוּ אֶת־עֲוֹנָם:

⁴¹*Yes, I will walk (yiqtol) with them in opposition, and I will bring (weqatal) them into a land of their enemies, or then(when) is humbled (ow-az yiqtol) their uncircumcised heart and then(when) they make amends (w-az yiqtol) for their iniquity, ⁴²I will remember (weqatal) my covenant with Jacob*

(4) Num 15:5-6

וַיִּזְיֶין לִנְסֹךְ רְבִיעִית הַהִין תַּעֲשֶׂה עַל־הָעֹלָה אִינוּ לְזֶבֶח
לְכָבֶשׂ הָאֶחָד:
⁶אוֹ לְאֵיל תַּעֲשֶׂה מִנְחָה סֵלֶת שְׁנֵי עֶשְׂרִים בִּלְוִלָה בַּשֶּׁמֶן שְׁלִשִׁית
הַהִין:

⁵*And wine for the drink offering, a fourth of a hin, you shall prepare (yiqtol) with the burnt offering, or for the sacrifice, for each lamb.*

⁶*Or for a ram, you shall prepare (yiqtol) for a cereal offering two tenths of an ephah of fine flour mixed with a third of a hin of oil RSV*

(5) 1Sam 26:10

וַיֹּאמֶר דָּוִד חִי־יְהוָה כִּי אִם־יְהוָה יִגְפֹּנוּ
אוֹ־יוֹמוֹ יָבוֹא וְיָמָת אוֹ בַּמִּלְחָמָה יָרֵד וְנִסְפָּה:

And David said, "As Yahweh lives, for Yahweh will smite (yiqtol) him.

*Or his day shall come (yiqtol) and he will die;
or into battle he shall go down (yiqtol) and perish.*

(6) Mal 1:8d

הֲיִרְצֶה אוֹ הַיֵּשָׁא פְנִיךָ אָמַר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת:

Will he be pleased with you (ha-yiqtol)

or lift up (*ha-yiqtol*) your face? says the LORD of hosts.

(7) Job 22:10-11

¹⁰Therefore snares surround (*qatal*) you And sudden terrors frighten (*weyiqtol*) you

אוֹחֲשֶׁךָ לֹא־תִרְאֶה וְשִׁפְעַת־מַיִם תִּכְסֶּכֶּךָ:

¹¹**or** darkness you do not see (*yiqtol*) and a flood of water covers (*yiqtol*) you. RSV

(8) Job 35:7

אִם־צִדִּיקָתָּ מִה־תִּתֶּן־לּוֹ אֹיֵךְ מִה־מִּידָךְ יִקַּח:

If you are righteous (*qatal*), what do you give (*yiqtol*) to him;

or what from your hand does he receive (*yiqtol*)?

See also: Exod 21:31; Lev 5:2,3,4;13:16,24;15:25; 25:49; Num 5:30; Deut 24:3; 1 Kings 20:39;21:6; Ezek 14:17,19; Job 3:16;12:8 ;38:31.

2.1.2 imperative + **וְ** X imperative

There are also two examples where the **וְ** conjunction coordinates two imperative commands:

(9) Isaiah 41:22

יִגִּישׁוּ וַיְגִידוּ לָנוּ אֶת אֲשֶׁר תִּקְרִינָה הָרֹאשִׁנוֹת מִהֶנָּה הַגִּידוּ

וְנִשְׁמָה לְבַבְנוּ וְנִדְעָה אַחֲרֵיתָן אֹיֵךְ הַבָּאוֹת הַשְּׂמִיעֵנוּ:

Let them bring them (*yiqtol*), and tell us (*weyiqtol* - *jussive*) what is to happen. Tell us (*imperative pl*) the former things, what they are, that we may consider (*weyiqtol* – *coh.*) them and that we may know (*weyiqtol* – *coh.*), their outcome; ^{RSV}

or the things to come declare (*imperative pl*) to us

(10) Jer 40:5

... וְשָׁבָה אֶל־גְּדַלְיָה בֶן־אֲחִיקָם בֶּן־שַׁפָּן אֲשֶׁר הָפְקִיד מֶלֶךְ־בָּבֶל

בְּעָרֵי יְהוּדָה וְשָׁב אִתּוֹ בְּתוֹךְ הָעָם

אֹיֵךְ אֶל־כָּל־הַיָּשָׁר בְּעֵינֶיךָ לָלֶכֶת לָךְ

... then return (*imperative*) to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, son of Shaphan, whom the king of Babylon appointed governor of the cities of Judah, and dwell (*imperative*) with him among the people;

or wherever you think it right to go, go (*imperative*)!

2.1.3 *qatal* + וְ X *qatal*

There are seven examples in which the sequence וְ X *qatal* is found: Leviticus (1x), Numbers (2x), Job (3x) and Isaiah (1x). All of the examples in Job coordinate rhetorical questions and all are found within one chapter.

(11) Lev 19:20

וְאִישׁ כִּי-יִשְׁכַּב אֶת-אִשְׁהּ שְׁכֵב־זָרַע וְהוּא שִׁפְחָהּ נִחְרַפֶּת לְאִישׁ
וְהִפְדָּהּ לֹא נִפְדָּתָהּ אֹחַ חֲפָזָהּ לֹא נִתַּן-לָהּ ...

If a man lies with a woman with an emission of seed and she is a slave, betrothed (participle) to another man and(but) has not been ransomed(qatal) or freedom has not been given (qatal), ...

(12) Num 14:2

וַיִּלְנוּ עַל-מֹשֶׁה וְעַל-אַהֲרֹן כָּל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וַיֹּאמְרוּ אֲלֵהֶם כָּל-הָעֵדָה
לֹא-מָתְנוּ בְּאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם אֹחַ בַּמִּדְבָּר הַזֶּה לֹא-מָתְנוּ:

And all the people of Israel murmured against Moses and Aaron; the whole congregation said to them, "Would that we had died (qatal) in the land of Egypt! Or would that we had died (qatal) in this wilderness! RSV

(13) Num 35:18

אֹחַ בְּכֵלִי עֵץ-יָד אֲשֶׁר-יָמוּת בּוֹ הִכָּהוּ וַיָּמָת רֹצֵחַ הוּא מוֹת יוֹמָת
הָרֹצֵחַ:

¹⁷*And if with a stone tool he struck him (qatal) and he died (wayyiqtol)...*

¹⁸*Or with an instrument of wood that he may die, he struck him (qatal) down and he died (wayyiqtol)*

(14) Job 38:5

מִי-שָׂם מִמְדֵּיהָ כִּי יִדָּע אֹחַ מִי-נֹטָה עָלֶיהָ קוֹ:

Who determined (qatal) its measurements -- surely you know! Or who stretched (qatal) the line upon it? RSV

(15) Job 38:6

עַל-מָה אֲדָגְיָהּ הִטְבְּעוּ אֹחַ מִי-יִרָה אָבֶן פְּנֵתָהּ:

On what were its bases sunk (qatal), or who laid (qatal) its cornerstone, RSV

2.2 **יֵא** + Verb

One might expect that when the verb immediately follows the **יֵא** conjunction, it will also copy the form of the verb preceding the conjunction, as is the case in the examples in 2.1. And since the majority of our examples use the *yiqtol* form of the verb, we might also expect that most of these examples would also be *yiqtol*. This is not the case. Of the 26 occurrences of **יֵא** + Verb, 20 are **יֵא** + *qatal*, while only three are **יֵא** + *yiqtol*, and a final three are **יֵא** + *qatal* (infinitive absolute).

2.2.1 *yiqtol* / *weqatal* + **יֵא** *qatal*

Upon further examination we discover that the majority of the occurrences of **יֵא** + *qatal* are preceded by a *yiqtol* verb and/or a *weqatal* verb. See examples (16) – (21) below.

(16) Exod 21:37

כִּי יִגְנֹב־אִישׁ שׁוֹר אוֹ-שֶׁה וּטְבָחוֹ
 אוֹ מִכְרוֹ חֲמִשָּׁה בָקָר יִשְׁלַם תַּחַת הַשּׁוֹר וְאַרְבַּע־צֹאן תַּחַת הַשֶּׁה:
*If a man steals (yiqtol) an ox or sheep, and slaughters (weqatal)
 or sells (owqatal) it*

(17) Exod 22:9

כִּי־יִתֵּן אִישׁ אֶל־רֵעֵהוּ חֲמֹר אוֹ-שׁוֹר אוֹ-שֶׁה וְכָל־בְּהֵמָה לְשֹׁמֵר וּמָת
 אוֹ־נִשְׁבֵּר אוֹ־נִשְׁבָּה אִין רָאָה:
*If a man gives (yiqtol) to his neighbour a donkey or ox or sheep
 or any livestock for safekeeping and it dies (weqatal) or is
 crippled (owqatal) or is captured (owqatal),*

(18) Exod 22:13

וְכִי־יִשְׁאַל אִישׁ מֵעַם רֵעֵהוּ וְנִשְׁבֵּר אוֹ־מָת
*And if a man borrows (yiqtol) from his neighbour and it is
 crippled (weqatal) or dies (owqatal).*

(19) Lev. 4.22-23

אֲשֶׁר נָשִׂיא יַחְטָא וְעָשָׂה אַחַת מִכָּל־מִצְוֹת יְהוָה אֲלֵהִיו
 אֲשֶׁר לֹא־תַעֲשִׂינָהּ בְּשִׁגְגָה וְאָשָׁם: ²³ אוֹ־הוֹדָע אֵלָיו חֲטָאתוֹ אֲשֶׁר
 חָטָא בָּהּ

*Where a leader sins (yiqtol) and does (weqatal) one of the
 commands of Yahweh his God which he was not to do, in error,
 and so incurs guilt (weqatal) upon himself*

²³ *or if it is made known (owqatal) to him his sin that he sinned
 in it, he shall bring*

(20) Lev 5:1

וְנָפֶשׁ כִּי־תִחַטָּא וְשָׁמְעָה קוֹל אֱלֹהִים וְהוּא עֹד
 אֹי רָאָה אֹי יָדַע אִם־לֹא יָגִיד וְנָשָׂא עוֹנֹו:

If any one sins (yiqtol) and he hears (weqatal) a public adjuration to testify and he is a witness, whether (or) he sees (owqatal) or knows (owqatal) the matter, yet does not speak, he shall bear his iniquity.

(21) 2 Sam18.12-13

וַיֹּאמֶר הָאִישׁ אֶל־יוֹאָב
 וְלֹא אֲנֹכִי שֶׁקֶל עַל־כַּפִּי אֶלֶף כֶּסֶף לֹא־אֶשְׁלַח יָדִי אֶל־בֶּן־הַמֶּלֶךְ
 כִּי בְּאָזְנוֹנוּ צִוָּה הַמֶּלֶךְ אֹתְךָ וְאֶת־אֲבִישִׁי וְאֶת־אֶתִּי לֵאמֹר
 שְׁמְרוּ־מִי בְּנֵעַר בְּאַבְשָׁלוֹם: ¹³ אֹי־עָשִׂיתִי בְּנִפְשׁוֹ שֶׁקֶר
 וְכָל־דָּבָר לֹא־יִכָּחַד מִן־הַמֶּלֶךְ וְאֹתָהּ תִּתִּיצֵב מִנֶּגֶד:

The man said to Joab, Even if I (have) a thousand silver shekels in my hands, I would not stretch forth (yiqtol) my hand against the son of a king, for in our hearing the king commanded you and... saying: Watch over for me the lad Absalom.

Or if I do (owqatal) treacherously against his life a (and there is nothing hidden from the king), then you yourself will stand aloof (yiqtol).

See also Lev 4:28; 5:21; 5:22; 22:4; Num 5:12; 35:20.

These examples appear to lead one to the hypothesis that **ix** acts like a *waw* consecutive. A further example (22) of multiple **ix** conjunctions, which exhibit **ix** X *yiqtol* and **ix** *qatal* side by side, lends further credence to the hypothesis:

(22) Lev 25:48b -49

אֶחָד מֵאֲחִיו יִגְאֹלֵנוּ: ⁴⁹ אֹי־דָדּוֹ אֹי בֶן־דָּדּוֹ יִגְאֹלֵנוּ
 אֹי־מִשְׁאֵר בְּשָׂרוֹ מִמִּשְׁפַּחְתּוֹ יִגְאֹלֵנוּ
 אֹי־הַשִּׁיגָה יָדוֹ וְנִגְאָל:

^{48b} *One of his kinsmen shall redeem (yiqtol) him*

⁴⁹ *or his uncle, or his cousin may redeem (ow X yiqtol) him,*

or a near kinsman belonging to his family may redeem (ow X yiqtol) him;

or (if) he grows rich (owqatal) he may redeem (weqatal) himself

2.2.2 **יֵא** *yiqtol*

Since it appears that the *waw* consecutive hypothesis applies in the *yiqtol* environment of the **יֵא** conjunction, we may ask whether it also applies to the *qatal* environment. If so, this means we should find *qatal* followed by **יֵא** *yiqtol*. There are only three occurrences of **יֵא** *yiqtol*, shown here in (23), (24) and (25). None of them, except possibly (25), are found in a *qatal* setting.

(23) Job 13:22

וְקָרָא וְאָנֹכִי אֶעֱנֶה **וְאִי־אֶדְבֶּר** וְהִשִּׁיבֵנִי:

And-call (imperative) and-I will answer (yiqtol)

or – let me speak(owyiqtol) and answer-me (imperative)

In Job 13:22 the context is imperative. Note that there is a chiasmic arrangement here, and the verb forms conform to the chiasm. It is definitely not a *waw* consecutive *yiqtol*!

(24) Isaiah 27:4-5

...מִי־יִתְּנֵנִי שָׁמִיר שִׁית בְּמַלְחָמָה אֶפְשָׁעָה בָּהּ אֲצִיתְנָה יַחַד:

אִוְ יַחַדְזָק בְּמַעוֹזִי יַעֲשֶׂה שָׁלוֹם לִי שָׁלוֹם יַעֲשֶׂה לִּי:

⁴... *Who will give me (yiqtol) thorns and thistles? In battle I will march (yiqtol) against her. I will kindle her (yiqtol) together.*

⁵ **Or let him hold fast (yiqtol-jussive)** to my refuge. Let him make (yiqtol) peace with me. Peace let him make(yiqtol) with me.

In (24) note first of all that there are no *waw* conjunctions connecting the sentences on either side of the **יֵא** conjunction; there are two sentence initial *yiqtol* verbs. Therefore we are in a context where the *waw* consecutive is not being used. Secondly, the **יֵא** *yiqtol* verb is actually jussive. It seems to be somewhat equivalent to a *weyiqtol* form. And thirdly, the **יֵא** conjunction is sentence initial presenting an alternative situation, even a contrasting situation.

The following passage in (25) has textual difficulties, yielding an uncertain interpretation. The general scholarly consensus seems to be that the sentence beginning with **יֵא** is first of all unintelligible and, secondly, was either an additional comment added by a later annotator, or else a product of copying errors and of attempts to correct it.³

3 See Greenberg (1997: 422-23) and Allen (1989: 67-71) for further discussion.

(25) Ezek 21:14b-15

חָרַב חָרַב הַיְחָדָה וְגַם-מְרוּטָהּ: ¹⁵ לְמַעַן טִבַּח טִבַּח הַיְחָדָה
 לְמַעַן-הֵי-לָהּ בָּרֶק מִרְטָה
 אוֹ נְשִׁישׁ יִשְׁבֹּט בְּנִי מֵאֶסֶת כָּל-עֵץ:

14b *A sword, a sword has been sharpened (qatal) and also burnished (qatal) 15 in order to wreak (inf. construct) slaughter. It has been sharpened to be (imperative) like lightning has burnished (qatal) (Greenberg (1997: 422): it has been burnished in order to flash.*

Or we will rejoice (or: shall we rejoice) rod of my son rejecting all trees.

The behaviour of the **וְ** sentence in this passage does not match the patterns that we have observed earlier. First of all, we find a *yiqtol* verb immediately after **וְ** in a larger environment which has *qatal* verbs. This is the only setting where one could possibly suggest a *waw* consecutive reading of the **וְ** *yiqtol*. However, no translator or commentator renders it thus and, considering the textual uncertainty, it is unwise to consider it as an example of any kind of pattern.

2.2.3 *qatal* + **וְ** *qatal*

Other than the example above, I have found no examples of *qatal* + **וְ** *yiqtol*. It appears that a *qatal* form does not “convert” when it immediately follows **וְ**. There are a few examples of **וְ** *qatal* in a *qatal* environment. We shall examine them now and attempt to discern whether we are dealing with a “converted” form or with a true *qatal*, or whether it really makes any difference! (I will explain further, below.)

(26) Num 11:8

שָׁטוּ הָעָם וַלְקָטוּ וְטָחְנוּ בִּרְחִים אוֹ דָּכְנוּ בְּמִדְכָּה וּבִשְׁלוּ בַּפָּרוֹר
 וַעֲשׂוּ אֹתוֹ עֲגֹת וְהָיָה טַעְמוֹ כְּטַעַם לֶשֶׁד הַשָּׂמֶן:

The people went about (qatal) and gathered (weqatal) it, and ground (weqatal) it in mills or beat (owqatal) it in mortars, and boiled (weqatal) it in pots, and made (weqatal) cakes of it; and the taste of it was (weqatal) like the taste of cakes baked with oil. RSV

The story in Numbers 11 begins with the Israelites complaining about having manna all the time and yearning for meat. Then the narrator inserts background information about the nature of the manna, how it was collected and prepared, and what it tasted like. The sentence (26) is part

of a paragraph providing this background information. The first verb is *qatal*; the context clearly shows that it was in a past habitual context, a context where *weqatal* is regularly used.

(27) Lev 15:2b-3

אִישׁ אִישׁ כִּי יִהְיֶה זָב מִבִּשְׁלֹו זֻבּוֹ טִמָּא הוּא:
 וְזֹאת תְּהִיָּה טִמְאַתּוֹ בְּזֻבּוֹ כִּי בִשְׁלֹו אֶת־זֻבּוֹ
 אֲוִי־הַחֲתָיִם בִּשְׁלֹו מִזֻּבּוֹ טִמְאַתּוֹ הוּא:

² Any man if he has (*yiqtol*) a discharge from his body, his discharge, it is unclean. ³ And this is (*yiqtol*) the uncleanness for a discharge:

His body runs (*qatal*) with his discharge, or his body is stopped
(owqatal) from discharge, it is uncleanness in him.

In (27) the *qatal* form preceding the conjunction is translated as a present tense. Note that the verbs in the previous sentence are all in *yiqtol*. Might the use of *qatal* be a way of referring back to a hypothetical action or event already described? At any rate, the **וְ** does not “convert” the *qatal* into a *yiqtol*.

(28) Num 30:4, 7, 10-11

⁴ If (*ki*) a woman vows (*yiqtol*) ... in the house of her father ...

⁷ If (*im*) she becomes (*inf.abs.* + *yiqtol*) to a man (i.e. married)...

¹⁰ The vow of a widow or a divorcée – all which she bound (*qatal*) herself shall be upheld (*yiqtol*).

11

וְאִם־בֵּית אִישָׁה נִדְרָה אֲוִי־אֶסְרָהּ אָסַר עַל־נַפְשָׁהּ בִּשְׁבָעָהּ:

And if (*im*) in the house of her husband she vowed (*qatal*) ...

or bound (owqatal) a bind on herself in her swearing...

In (28) we are dealing again with a hypothetical action already described in a previous verse (vs. 6). The case of swearing the oath is presented, then the conditions are presented: if this oath-taking previously mentioned was done by a divorcée or a widow, or if it was done by a married woman. In each case the use of the *qatal* refers back to the act of oath-taking mentioned in verse 6. Here the verb after **וְ** does not “convert” to *yiqtol*. It remains *qatal*.

The next example (29) is set in a series of cases specifying differing kinds of intentional murder and unintentional murder. The goal of this

text is to specify who would qualify for refuge in a city of refuge, and who would not.

(29) Num 35: 15-23

These six cities shall serve (yiqtol) the Israelites and the resident aliens among them for refuge, so that anyone who kills (participle) a person unintentionally may flee there. JPS

¹⁶*And (but) if with an iron object, he struck him (qatal) and he died (wayyiqtol)*

¹⁷*And-if with a stone tool he struck him (qatal) and he died (wayyiqtol)...*

¹⁸

אוּ בְכָלִי עֶצֶיִד אֲשֶׁר־יָמוּת בּוֹ הַכָּהוּ וַיָּמָת רֹצֵחַ הוּא מוֹת יוֹמָת
הָרֹצֵחַ:

Or with an instrument of wood that he may die, he struck him (qatal) down and he died (wayyiqtol)...

¹⁹*The blood avenger himself shall put him to death (yiqtol) upon encounter.*

²⁰

וְאִם־בְּשִׁנְאָה יִהְדָּפֵנוּ אוֹ־הַשְּׁלִיף עָלָיו בְּצָדָה וַיָּמָת:

And if in hatred he stabs (yiqtol) him,

or hurls (owqatal) at him, lying in wait, so that he died,

²¹

אוּ בְּאִיבָה הַכָּהוּ בְּיָדוֹ וַיָּמָת

מוֹת־יוֹמָת הַמַּכָּה רֹצֵחַ הוּא גַּאֵל הַדָּם יָמִית אֶת־הָרֹצֵחַ בְּפָגְעוֹ־בּוֹ:

OR in enmity struck him down (qatal) with his hand, so that he died (wayyiqtol), then he who struck the blow shall be put to death (yiqtol); he is a murderer; the avenger of blood shall put the murderer to death (yiqtol), when he meets him. RSV

²²

וְאִם־בְּפִתְעָ בְּלֹא־אִיבָה הִדָּפוּ אוֹ־הַשְּׁלִיף עָלָיו כָּל־כְּלִי בְּלֹא צָדָה:

“But if he stabbed (qatal) him suddenly without enmity, or

hurled (owqatal) anything on him without lying in wait,

²³

אוּ בְּכָל־אֶבֶן אֲשֶׁר־יָמוּת בָּהּ בְּלֹא רְאוּת וַיִּפֹּל עָלָיו

וַיָּמָת וְהוּא לֹא־אוֹיֵב לוֹ וְלֹא מִבְּקֶשׁ רָעָתוֹ:

Or used a stone, by which a man may die, and without seeing him cast it (wayyiqtol) upon him, so that he died (wayyiqtol), though he was not his enemy, and did not seek his harm; RSV

The reader will note variant uses of the conjunctions: some clauses are prefaced by ‘and’ (*waw*), while others are prefaced by ‘or’ (*ix*), when in actuality they all mean ‘or.’ Likewise, the use of *yiqtol* and *qatal* varies. The qualifications for refuge are presented, for the most part, in *qatal* form: two *ix* clauses are - *ix* X *qatal*, while two others are - *ix* *qatal*. Of these latter two, one is preceded by a *qatal* (vs.22), and the other is preceded by a *yiqtol* (vs.20).

These examples show that a verb found immediately after *ix* is *qatal*, when in the *qatal* environment. In other words, there is no *waw* consecutive-type behaviour for *ix* conjunctions set in a *qatal* environment. In addition, we recall that, while *ix* + Verb is *qatal* in a *qatal* environment, it is **also** *qatal* in a *yiqtol* environment, unless there is an intervening particle between the conjunction and the verb, and unless the *ix* *yiqtol* form itself expresses an injunctive mood.

What might this mean? That the *wayyiqtol* form does have historical roots in a narrative past tense form, for which the sense of sequentiality remained intact, therefore making it inappropriate for the *ix* *yiqtol* form to have a potential ‘conversive’ function? Or that the *qatal* form became a default form which was meant simply to express an alternative action, and which was not marked for tense or aspect?

2.2.4 *ix* *qatol* (infinitive absolute)

Finally, there are three instances where an infinitive absolute functions as a finite verb immediately after the *ix* conjunction:

(30) Lev 25:14

וְכִי־תִמְכְּרוּ מִמְכָּרְ לַעֲמִיתְךָ
 אֹו קְנָה מִיַּד עֲמִיתְךָ אֶל־תּוֹנוּ אִישׁ אֶת־אָחִיו:

*And if you sell (yiqtol) merchandise to your fellow
 or buy (owqatol) from your fellow, do not wrong one another.*

(31) Num 30:3

אִישׁ כִּי־יִדָּר נָדָר לַיהוָה
 אֹו־הִשָּׁבַע שְׁבַעַה לְאָסָר אָסָר עַל־נַפְשׁוֹ

If a man vows (yiqtol) a vow to Yahweh or swears (owqatol) an oath

(32) Deut 14:21

לֹא תֹאכְלוּ כָל־נֶבֶלָה לְגֵר אֲשֶׁר־בְּשַׁעְרֶיךָ תִּתְּנֶנָּה וְאָכְלָה

וְאֵין מִכֹּר לְנֶכְרִי

*Do not eat (yiqtol) carcass; to an alien who is in your walls give (yiqtol) it that he may eat (weqatal) it **or** sell (owqatal) to a foreigner.*

There does not appear to be any semantic difference between these three and the previous set of **וְ** *qatal* sentences. Whether the author had some specific reason, discourse or otherwise, to mark the text with these infrequent syntactic combinations remains unknown at this point. In all three cases the *yiqtol/weqatal* forms occur in the clause preceding **וְ**.

Interestingly, the situation we find here is paralleled by several dozen examples of *waw* + *qatal* throughout the Bible. A few authors have attempted to provide some possible explanations for this phenomenon. Rubenstein (1952: 365) noted that these forms were frequently found in instances where one might expect the *waw* consecutive. He further observed that *waw* + *qatal* forms were somewhat more frequent in later literature, such as Esther (9x) and Jeremiah (10x). He drew the conclusion that in a later development or because of the influence of a local dialect, *qatal* began replacing the *waw* consecutive, and that copyists sometimes made mistakes in pointing in order to favour the *qatal* reading. Huesman (1956: 410-434), too, faults the copyists but for entirely different reasons. According to him, many of the awkward grammatical readings of verbs throughout the Bible, including the weak *waw* + perfect, could be resolved by attributing an original pointing for the infinitive absolute form. He provides several dozen examples in order to prove his point. He believes the copyists made the opposite mistake of not recognizing the *qatal* forms, and therefore made errors in pointing.

Although neither of these authors mentions any cases of **וְ** followed by the absolute infinitive, Waltke (1990: 596) does include two of the above examples in his list of examples of a conjunction followed by the absolute infinitive, though he makes no further comment as to their inclusion in the list. To date no clear explanation has been given for the use of the infinitive absolute in the place of a *waw* consecutive verb form, most likely because this isolated form of syntax is scattered throughout the Bible, and does not show any clear patterns of distribution. The speculation that it was a dialectal alternative to the *waw* consecutive does remain a possibility. It is clear, however, that the **וְ** conjunction seems to be also included in this alternative speech.

Above we noted the possibility that the *qatal* form seemed to be a kind of default form in **וְ** + Verb constructions; the *qatal* form is even more

neutral as regards to tense, aspect and mode (TAM). Together both forms seem to show a tendency not to mark the verb for TAM in the *iŋ* + Verb construction.

2.3 Statistical Summary

Below are the statistics concerning the structure and verb forms of the clauses conjoined by *iŋ*:

2.3.1 Same or different verb forms:

Same: <i>Verb₁</i> + <i>iŋ</i> (X) <i>Verb₁</i>		Different: <i>Verb₁</i> + <i>iŋ</i> (X) <i>Verb₂</i>	
Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> X yiqtol	26	Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatal	16
Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> X qatal	6	Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatol	3
Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatal	4	Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> yiqtol	1
Imperative + <i>iŋ</i> X imperative	2		
Yiqtol + <i>iŋ</i> yiqtol	2		
TOTAL	40	TOTAL	20

2.3.2 With or without an element between *iŋ* and the verb

With: <i>Verb</i> + <i>iŋ</i> X <i>Verb</i>		Without: <i>Verb</i> + <i>iŋ</i> <i>Verb</i>	
Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> X yiqtol	26	Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatal	16
Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> X qatal	6	Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatal	4
Imperative + <i>iŋ</i> X imperative	2	Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatol	3
		Yiqtol + <i>iŋ</i> yiqtol	2
		Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> yiqtol	1
TOTAL	34	TOTAL	26

2.3.3 Total Count

Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> X yiqtol	26
Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatal	16
Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> X qatal	6
Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatal	4
Yiqtol/weqatal + <i>iŋ</i> qatol	3
Imperative + <i>iŋ</i> X imperative	2
Yiqtol + <i>iŋ</i> yiqtol	2
Qatal + <i>iŋ</i> yiqtol	1
TOTAL	60

Clearly the *iŋ* X *yiqtol* and the *iŋ* *qatal* forms are the most frequent. Combined, they account for over two thirds of the examples.

3. ANALYSIS

The statistics give the appearance that a *waw* conversive effect dominates. However, taking into consideration the other data, we propose the hypothesis that the *qatal* form is inserted immediately after the *ix* conjunction as a neutral form, unmarked for tense, aspect and mode. It would be automatically interpreted as carrying the same tense, aspect and modal (TAM) sense as the previous verb with which it is coordinated by the *ix* conjunction. When another element separates *ix* from the verb, the syntax requires a re-specification of the TAM. Thus we see *qatal* + *ix* X *qatal*, *yiqtol* + *ix* X *yiqtol*, and imperative + *ix* X imperative. As for *ix yiqtol* forms, we discern a specified injunctive mood, somewhat equivalent to the *weyiqtol* verb forms.

ix + infinitive absolute is rare. Since it is neutral in terms of tense and aspect, it can be adapted to the tense and aspect given in its grammatical context, just as is observed for *ix* + *qatal* sequence. However, the one major difference between these two forms is that the *qatal* can be conjugated for person and number but the *qatol* cannot.

The modal environment of almost all of these examples is irrealis or iterative, even in the cases where the *qatal* form is used. When the *qatal* is in the protasis, it generally refers to a past time anterior to the hypothetical action under discussion. However, the governing *yiqtol* verb generally sets the mood for irrealis, as can be seen in the example (29) above. While the irrealis mood can be expressed by either *qatal* (hypothetical past anterior) or *yiqtol* (setting the irrealis point of reference) forms⁴, the *ix qatal* forms do not mark a past anterior unless they are coordinated with a verb which is also past anterior (see (28)).

4. IMPLICATIONS FOR TRANSLATION OF *ix* QATAL FORMS

Generally, *qatal* forms are translated into past tense forms in English. (See Numbers 30:6-11 (28) and Numbers 35:15-23 (29).) However, if in some language a past tense form designates an activity which actually took place, one could not use the past tense for statements which are irrealis, such as conditionals, commands, future and hypothetical statements.

Since *ix qatal* seem to be a default form, without its own TAM sense, how do we then translate? English translations frequently follow the TAM sense of the clause preceding the conjunction. Note (33) below from the NIV translation.

4 The *wayyiqtol* verb form can also likewise be found in the same irrealis environment, as seen in Num 35:18, example (29)).

(33) Exod 22:1 (21:37)

*If a man steals (**yiqtol**) an ox or a sheep and slaughters (**weqatal**) it or sells (**owqatal**) it. NIV*

In a few cases the translator opts for a past tense form of the verb for the **iR qatal** verb in a setting where there is room for doubt. We consider a few such cases now.

(34) 2 Sam. 18.11-13

*Joab said to the man, “What! You saw him? Why didn’t you strike him to the ground right there?....¹² Even if a thousand shekels were weighed out into my hands, I would not lift (**yiqtol**) my hand against the king’s son. In our hearing the king commanded (**qatal**) you and Abishai and Ittai, ‘Protect the young man Absalom for my sake.’*

¹³*And (or) if I had put my life in jeopardy (**owqatal**) – and nothing is hidden from the king – you would have kept your distance (**yiqtol**) from me. NIV (See (21) above for the Hebrew.)*

The passage in (34) is referring back to an action not done, and about possible hypothetical consequences had the soldier killed Absalom. But the sentence could also have been translated: “If I put my life in jeopardy ... you would keep your distance from me”. In effect, the soldier is both explaining his lack of action and his refusal to comply with Joab’s wishes.

(35) Lev 5:1

*If a person sins (**yiqtol**) because he does not speak up (**yiqtol**) when he hears (**weqatal**) a public charge to testify regarding something he has seen (**owqatal**) or learned about (**owqatal**), he will be held responsible (**weqatal**) NIV. (Lit. If any one sins (**yiqtol**) and he hears (**weqatal**) a public adjuration to testify and he is a witness, whether (or) he sees (**owqatal**) or knows (**owqatal**), yet does not speak, he shall bear his iniquity.)*

Again, in (35) the translator considers the context and assumes that the witnessing took place prior to the hypothetical public adjuration. However, the syntax and verb forms could also indicate that the rule would apply to anything also heard or seen after the public adjuration. The point here is that the **iR qatal** cannot specify a hypothetical past in itself and, being in a **yiqtol** environment, one might be inclined to take the latter interpretation.

(36) Exod 21:35-36

*If a man's bull injures (**yiqtol**) the bull of another and it dies (**weqatal**), they are to sell (**weqatal**) the live one and divide (**weqatal**) both the money and (**yiqtol**) the dead animal equally.*
 36 *However, if it was known (**owqatal**)* *that the bull had the habit of goring, yet the owner did not keep it penned up (**yiqtol**), the owner must pay NIV*

In (36) *ix qatal* is translated with a past tense form, even though every single verb form preceding the conjunction is *yiqtol* or *weqatal*. Again the *qatal* form immediately after the *ix* conjunction cannot determine this past tense meaning. Rather the translator looked ahead to the subordinating explanatory clause (lit. that the bull a gorer he was yesterday and before), and set it in the hypothetical past. While the NRSV, NIV and GWT translate in this way, other translations translate as “Or if it is known” (BBE, RSV), or “Or if it be known” (ASV, Darby) or “Or if it shall be known” (Webster). Logically the knowledge of the bull’s habits would not just be a past tense activity in relation to the murderous goring; it would also be contemporaneous with the murderous goring event, and continue beyond the goring event. Therefore I would contend that the *ix qatal* form here is not meant to express a hypothetical past tense, but simply a hypothetical event co-occurring with the hypothetical goring event. The past tense in English would be more natural in the event that the offending bull was already dead, or otherwise no longer goring.⁵ But this is not the case here.

These examples further show that an *ix qatal* form adopts its TAM from the context, first of all from the clause preceding the conjunction and secondly from the wider context. This means that in translation the verbal context of the *ix qatal* form must be studied carefully, as well as the verbal behaviour of the target language before deciding upon an appropriate translation. It is clear that one cannot automatically suppose that the *ix qatal* form indicates past tense. This study underlines the fact once again that numerous factors must be taken into consideration when translating verb forms from Biblical Hebrew into other languages.

5 Compare the sentences: ‘That man was known for his laziness,’ and ‘That man is known for his laziness.’ In the first we draw the conclusion that the man is no longer lazy. Either he died and someone is reminiscing, or he is living and he changed behaviour somewhere along the way. In the second the event co-occurs with the statement of the event. One can easily imagine the statement being made after observing the latest of numerous displays of his laziness. We could even speculate that a boss is instructing a foreman on a construction job: ‘If a man refuses an order, investigate what the problem is. However, if he is known for his laziness, fire him immediately.’ If one accepts this line of argumentation, then the translation, ‘If it is known ...’ would be more natural for Exodus 21:36.

5. CONCLUSIONS

Much has been written on the possible historical roots of the *qatal* and *yiqtol* verb forms and their respective meanings and functions in Biblical Hebrew⁶. This paper introduces data that can further the discussion with reference to the environment of the disjunctive conjunction, **וְ**. How then do these findings on the **וְ** *qatal* link up with observations of the *weqatal*? I note here a few observations worthy of further consideration.

The use of the *weqatal* in the irrealis/iterative modal environment of the **וְ** conjunction parallels the use of the **וְ** *qatal* form. In the light of our posited unmarked value of the **וְ** *qatal* form, it might be instructive to re-examine the default function of the *weqatal* form.⁷

From a diachronic perspective, it has been suggested that the *wayyiqtol* form developed from an earlier preterite form, and that the *weqatal* form evolved as an analogical extension of the *wayyiqtol*. Now since it appears that one could replace **וְ** with *waw* in many contexts (*waw* meaning ‘and’ or ‘or,’ (**וְ** rarely meaning ‘and’)), might it be possible that **וְ** + verb was also subjected to this analogical extension? If this is so, it is clear that the analogy did not carry to its final conclusion: there are no true *qatal* + **וְ** *yiqtol* (converted) constructions.

Another topic which awaits further examination is the distribution of **וְ** in relation to *waw*. We noted a couple of texts where both *waw* and **וְ** are used, both meaning ‘or.’ A syntactic and discourse analysis of this and other passages could help provide clues to the functional distribution of these two conjunctions.

6

See the bibliography for a list of publications that were consulted.

7

The notion of default function helps to explain verbal behaviour in African languages such as Senufo, where the basic verb form, without any suffixing, will be imperative in sentence initial position; but the same form is used in specified past tense and future tense contexts. Likewise, it might be useful to suggest the possibility that *qatal* be assigned the default value of ‘past tense’. If this is the case, then one could say that the *qatal* form will acquire the TAM value of the verbal context in which it is found. If, though, there is no specified verbal context, then it is assigned the default TAM value of the indicative past. See Talstra (1997) and Peckham (1997) on the use of textual context for the semantic interpretation of the *qatal* and *weqatal* forms, Rogland (2003) on the sense of past tense for *qatal*, and Momo (2005) on the sense of imperfective for *weqatal*.

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